

RANCHI | Brotherly Bother

One of the first things Shibu Soren did after becoming Jharkhand's chief minister was to ask the Naxalites for advice on running his Government. Soren unashamedly calls himself the "biggest Naxalite" and refers to Maoists as "brothers and sisters". The Maoists replied by blowing up a vehicle on January 15, killing six policemen and a civilian. To assert his rather loose grip on law and order, Soren has retained the home portfolio after wrangling with his coalition partners. After the attack, Soren has again offered the Maoists an olive branch, asking them to give up violence for dialogue and leaving the police department confused. Though the Maoists are yet to respond, Soren's overture to the



rebels has now left the state cops confused. "The Maoists can either be our brothers and sisters or brutal killers," said Dinesh Narayan Singh, a Jharkhand Police Association official.

by Amitabh Srivastava

AHMEDABAD | Prides and Prejudice

The fate of Asiatic lions in Gujarat's Gir sanctuary now lies with the Supreme Court. The Biodiversity Conservation Trust, a conservation body, has filed a PIL in the apex court seeking implementation of the Centre-aided project for the relocation of the lions to Kuno-Palpur in Madhya Pradesh. The Gujarat Government has long

claimed that the tigers that are still there in Kuno-Palpur can't coexist with the lions from Gir, basing it on the fact that the same experiment when first carried out on a smaller scale had failed in the 1980s. The actual reason for Gujarat's opposition, however, is that local politicians cutting across party lines have made it an issue of pride. There is

also a fear that shifting the lions from Gir would hit its tourist inflows. The state Government has increased the land mass for lions in Bhavnagar and Porbandar and created a new sanctuary for them. Union Environment and Forest Minister Jairam Ramesh has also tried to convince Gujarat to shift the lions to Madhya Pradesh but to no avail.

by Uday Mahurkar

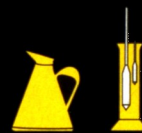


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